

THE FALL OF A HEAVYWEIGHT

PARTHA CHATTERJEE, 69
Former cabinet minister,
West Bengal

Armed with an MBA degree, Partha Chatterjee quit his HR job in Andrew Yule to join politics in 1998. He is an old loyalist of Mamata Banerjee who has stuck by her from the time when TMC's MLAs accounted for less than one-fifth of the 294-member Bengal assembly. He contested his first assembly polls in 2001 from Behala Paschim and has won it five times in a row. A strong organisation man, he emerged as Mamata's go-to person in running the party. He has held important portfolios—leader of the Opposition in the assembly between 2006 and 2011, deputy leader of the house in 2011, secretary general of TMC, head of the party's disciplinary commitee and several cabinet posts. He was education minister from 2014 to 2021. One thing Mamata has disapproved about Chatterjee is his ample girth. The TMC chief has body-shamed him in public on multiple occasions.



THE CASH QUEEN

ARPITA MUKHERJEE, 36
Model, actress, producer

Born in a middle-class family, Arpita's father was a central government employee. A small-time model, she acted in minor roles in Bengali, Odia and Tamil films. Around a decade ago, she was introduced to minister Partha Chatterjee by a businessman. She soon began accompanying Chatterjee to public events, becoming the face of the Naktala Udayan Sangha Durga Puja committee, of which Chatterjee is the chief patron. Arpita moved to an apartment in an upscale housing complex in south Kolkata, from where the ED recovered Rs 20 crore in cash, foreign currency and a cache of incriminating documents. From another flat owned by her, it seized Rs 30 crore. Arpita claims Chatterjee used her Aadhaar and PAN card to buy properties in her name and that she had little clue about it all.

Soon, it was found that many aspirants way down in the waiting list had allegedly jumped ranks and got appointment letters. Even unsuccessful candidates—neither empanelled nor on the waiting list—were said to have made it. For instance, 31-year-old Rabibur Sheikh, ranked 186, was surprised to find the candidate placed 194 getting appointed ahead of him. In September 2021, the petitioners again knocked at the door of the high court and Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya asked the WBSSC to address all their concerns.

THE EXPOSÉ

On February 21, 2022, when the commission filed a detailed response, the case was listed in the court of Justice Ganguly, who asked it to furnish answers to specific questions. When the WBSSC admitted that the appointment of one Insan Ali, ranked 144 in the waiting list, was an inadvertent error, Justice Ganguly

THE SLST TEST WAS HELD IN 2016, BUT FULL MERIT LISTS WITH SCORES WERE RELEASED ONLY BETWEEN JULY 14 AND JULY 20, 2022

refused to accept it. He declared Ali's appointment illegal and asked the chairman of the WBSSC to appear before him. On February 28, the officials told the court they had "no idea" who issued the appointment letters and that the signatures on them were "mechanically printed". They did, however, name two persons who may have known more—Shanti Prasad Sinha, advisor to the commission, and Samarjit Acharya, its programme officer.

On March 3, Justice Ganguly ordered a CBI probe into the alleged irregularities. The state government challenged the order before a two-judge bench, which stayed the CBI probe and set up an inquiry panel headed by retired judge Ranjit Bag. The three-member panel, however, concurred with all of Justice Ganguly's observations. On May 18, a different two-judge bench upheld Ganguly's order for a CBI inquiry. It also observed that at the root of